> the confidence of the Natives and of the Europeans, who is capable of directing military operations, and who, by his personal authority, which in India is everything, can compel all his subordinate officials to co-operate in his policy and in carrying out the wishes of Her Majesty's Government [emphasis added].

In fact, a Proclamation dated 1 November 1858 was indeed issued by Queen Victoria, which is often cited as proof of British neutrality in matters of religion. The relevant portion of the Proclamation which contains cues on the nature of this toleration and neutrality[7] is as follows:

> *Firmly relying ourselves on the truth of Christianity,* and acknowledging with gratitude the solace of religion, we disclaim alike the right and desire to impose our convictions on any of our subjects. We declare it to be our royal will and pleasure that none be in anywise favoured, none molested or disquieted, by reason of their religious faith or observances, but that all alike shall enjoy the equal and impartial protection of the law; and we do strictly charge and enjoin all those who may be in authority under us that they abstain from all interference with the religious belief or worship of any of our subjects on pain of our highest displeasure [emphasis added].

The language of the Proclamation itself is proof of the fact that the freedom of religion promised therein was rooted in the political theology of Christian freedom, as De Roover puts it. This is also evidenced by the language of the debates preceding the 1858 Act, as shall be seen in the ensuing portions. On 16 July 1858,[8] the Bishop of Oxford:

> then proposed an addition to the clause vesting the right of nominating to chaplaincies in India in future alternately in the Crown and in the Bishop of the diocese in which the chaplaincies were situated. He hoped he should have the concurrence of Her Majesty's Government on the subject. *From the commencement of legislation in connection with the East India Company they were bound to maintain and provide certain chaplains and ministers for their principal factories. Hitherto these appointments had been made by the Board of Directors at home, but under this clause they would transfer the appointment of all these*